Board Brief

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THE PROBLEM

Our DAU has been flat for 3 months and I can't find the cause.

Context: We're a Series B company with ~180K MAU. Our core user is a mid-market ops manager using us daily for workflow approvals. The flatness started around February — roughly 3 weeks after we shipped a redesigned home screen.

What I've already tried: cohort analysis (no single segment is dropping, it's broad), a quick user survey (mixed signals), and reverting one UI change (no movement).

Main constraint: unclear signal — the data isn't pointing anywhere obvious and the team is split on whether this is a product problem or a seasonality blip.

YOUR BOARD

VISIONARY **Albert Cheng**

Lenny's Podcast

The root of your DAU stagnation isn't purely about user confusion from the redesigned home screen; it signals a deeper structu issue with your product-market fit. To paraphrase Lenny's insights, successful products often root their foundation in cost efficie and scrappiness. The current flatness in DAU indicates a lack of compelling, sustained engagement with your offering—someth deeper than just UI tweaks.

You've already tried surface-level diagnostics, but the bet here isn't simply a matter of fixing user experience. Focus on the criti operational pain points that your mid-market ops managers face daily and pivot from merely enhancing features to radically understanding and addressing these pain points. What operational hurdles are they continually encountering that make them disengage? Are they fully leveraging your tool's capabilities, and if not, why?

The action item here is to launch an initiative that digs deep into the daily workflow challenges of a subset of users—conduct int support sessions or shadow a few key users for a week. The insights will demand a transformative approach to the product—no incremental improvements.

CHALLENGER **Elena Verna 4.0**

Lenny's Podcast

Let’s interrogate the framing of the problem. The focus on flat DAU may be masking a more fundamental issue: the core product experience itself and its alignment with user needs. You’ve implemented changes that didn’t yield the expected engagement, yet you’re still treating symptoms (flat DAU, mixed survey responses) rather than investigating whether your users’ workflows are effectively supported by your redesign.

You mentioned engaging with cohort analysis, but if every cohort shows no drop, can we ask if they’re even getting value from the experience as it currently stands? Remember John Cutler’s insight about software — it evolves through capability stages. If your redesigned home screen compromised usability or limited access to key workflows, the result could indeed be stagnant DAUs irrespective of traffic from new users.

Before diving deeper into tactics or research, let’s reframe the issue: What if the problem is not just about flat DAU but about the perceived value users get from your product? Start with a usability audit of the redesign. Identify if the new capabilities have disrupted the flow, rather than sticking to the assumption that familiarity is enough.

OPERATOR **Amol Avasare**

Lenny's Podcast

The flat DAU is a classic signal that something's off, and your instincts on the UI change are likely correct—they set the stage for a ripple effect. It’s not just a product issue; it’s a carousel of user experience, especially if that redesign misaligned with the user's workflow approval needs.

You mentioned mixed signals from the survey, which tells me we haven’t pinpointed the user's friction points. I’d push you to get more granular here: instead of broad surveys, conduct user sessions with those ops managers. Observe their workflows in real-time—get them to use the product and show them exactly where they struggle. This isn’t just about asking questions; it’s about witnessing pain points firsthand.

As for next steps, who is going to take ownership of organizing these user observation sessions? You need a named owner with a deadline—set it for early next week. Get those insights to identify what’s blocking the user journey and translate that into actionable fixes.

USER ADVOCATE **Aishwarya Naresh Reganti + Kiriti Badam**

Lenny's Podcast

The flat DAU is likely a symptom of overlooked user experience issues stemming from the redesigned home screen. While the team is debating whether this is a product issue or just seasonality, I urge you to remember that users are often very sensitive to changes in their daily workflows—especially ops managers, who thrive on efficiency and reliability.

When you disrupt their visual familiarity without enough user testing or feedback loops, it can lead to disengagement. Referring back to the insights shared by Lenny: once users are comfortable with a flow—like using drafts—they don't want roadblocks. If that redesigned home screen has introduced friction or confusion, it could be steering them away from returning daily.

Instead of hunting for abstract metrics or placating to seasonal explanations, let's roll back the home screen for a limited segment of our users to see if a return to the familiar boosts engagement. This isn't just about flat numbers—it's about ensuring our users feel supported and confident in their daily tasks.

DATA ORACLE **Nicole Forsgren**

Lenny's Podcast

Let's stop speculating about cause and start measuring the outcomes. When faced with flat DAU after a redesign, the core question is: what does the data actually show versus what the team believes it shows? You've performed cohort analysis without finding a drop in any segment, but that suggests the flatness isn't a product issue for a specific cohort—it might be more pervasive.

What about measuring user engagement metrics beyond DAU? Are you tracking session length, feature usage, or task completion rates? Specifically, let's establish a segmentation cut by user activity levels. Are your most engaged users remaining engaged? If yes, is the flat DAU primarily due to a loss of sporadic users, indicating a product experience problem rather than a seasonal one?

We need to gather and analyze this data to get to the core issue. Focus on understanding who is benefiting from your product in this new layout; does the redesigned home screen resonate with everyone's workflows?

Action: Track session length and feature usage over the next month segmented by user engagement levels, particularly examining sporadic users.

THE DEBATE

Albert Cheng to Aishwarya Naresh Reganti: Rolling back the home screen for a limited segment of users is a reactive measure that avoids addressing the deeper structural issue of product-market fit and operational hurdles. We need to focus on understanding the daily workflow challenges of ops managers instead of reverting to old designs.

Aishwarya Naresh Reganti: Users need a product that supports their efficiency, and if the redesign has introduced friction, we must test the waters by restoring familiarity—it's about ensuring user confidence in their daily tasks, not just structural issues.

> *The pattern I've seen across dozens of conversations is that product issues often stem from a misalignment between user needs and perceived value, rather than surface-level changes like a UI redesign. The tension you're experiencing—whether it's a product problem or seasonality—suggests a deeper inquiry into how well your product actually solves the core operational pain points of your users. From my observations, the most successful teams pivot from merely analyzing metrics to deeply understanding and adapting to the evolving needs and workflows of their users, ensuring the product remains indispensable and valuable.*

LENNY'S TAKE

SYNTHESIS

WHAT THE BOARD AGREES

The board unanimously agrees that the recent DAU stagnation is linked to the redesigned home screen. They see the redesign as the catalyst, impacting user engagement and potentially masking deeper issues within the product itself.

THE OPEN QUESTION

The unresolved tension lies between Albert Cheng and Aishwarya Naresh Reganti + Kiriti Badam. Albert contends that the flat DAU is a symptom of a deeper structural issue, urging a transformative approach through in-depth explorations of user workflow challenges. In contrast, Aishwarya and Kiriti strongly believe that the main issue stems directly from the redesign – suggesting a simple rollback of the home screen for some users to test if it restores engagement. The PM must decide whether to explore deeper product-market misalignments or focus on immediately rectifying the user experience by restoring the previous home screen.

YOUR NEXT MOVE

The most crucial next action is to initiate a rollback of the redesigned home screen for a defined segment of users by the end of the week. This decision is feasible and actionable, allowing the team to collect quick feedback on whether returning to the familiar interface increases user engagement, or if deeper issues are indeed at play. This move will provide immediate signals to help navigate further product decisions.

PICK YOUR MOVE — THREE PATHS FORWARD

Deep User Engagement

' CHOSEN PATH

Launch an initiative to conduct intimate support sessions and shadow a subset of key users over a week to identify operational points and transform the product.

Why this works: This approach allows for a deeper understanding of the daily challenges faced by mid-market ops managers, potentially uncovering structural product-market misalignments that are more significant than UI issues.

Backed by Albert Cheng

Usability Audit and Redesign Fix

Conduct a comprehensive usability audit of the redesigned home screen to identify disruptions in user flow and adjust the desig better align with user workflows.

Why this works: By addressing the possible usability issues introduced by the redesign, we can ensure that the product aligns with users' needs, enhancing perceived value and possibly boosting engagement.

Backed by Elena Verna 4.0

Rollback Test for Engagement

Rollback the redesigned home screen for a specific user segment to test if a return to the familiar layout improves their engage

Why this works: This immediate and practical test can quickly determine if the design change is the main cause of DAU stagnation, enabling swift action to restore user confidence and engagement.

Backed by Aishwarya Naresh Reganti + Kiriti Badam